Border demarcation in the west is even hazier than in the east, mainly because of the scarcity of people in the area and the absence of any significant trade across the mountains. Ladakh, though, was an independent kingdom inhabited by ethnic Tibetan tribes who practised the Tibetan form of Buddhism, maintained relations with Tibet as well as Bhutan. But in 1834, forces from the Sikh Empire of the Punjab plains annexed Ladakh, which finally lost its independence six years later. In 1846, Ladakh was incorporated into Jammu and Kashmir, a new princely state which under a treaty signed in Amritsar acknowledged British paramountcy within the Indian empire.[49] High mountain ranges and what was described as 'natural elements' became the frontier separating the Ladakh area from those to the north still under Tibetan or Chinese influence—but there were different views on exactly which 'elements' these should be.

According to the 1846 Treaty of Amritsar, the northern frontier with Tibet was to be defined by commissioners appointed by the British East India Company and Gulab Singh Dogra, the Maharaja of Jammu and Kashmir. William H. Johnson, a British surveyor, became the governor of Ladakh under the Maharaja, and, in 1865, he proposed a boundary through Aksai Chin that would touch the Kunlun range, the highest mountains in the area. This boundary was formally proposed to the government of British India in 1897 by the chief of British military intelligence in London, Major General Sir John Ardagh. Subsequently, it became known as the Ardagh-Johnson Line.[50]

The Chinese never recognized the Ardagh-Johnson Line, and, in 1892, one of their patrols erected some border markers at the Karakoram Pass, where there was an ancient caravan route between Xinjiang and Ladakh. Since then, the Chinese have continued to claim that the greater part of Ladakh's Aksai Chin region should be inside the territory claimed by them. The British did not pay much attention to the Chinese moves in this remote and inhospitable area, and, in order to create yet another buffer zone between the expanding Russian Empire and Tibet, a new boundary was drawn in 1893. It became known as the MacCartney-MacDonald Line and placed most of Aksai Chin on the Chinese side of the boundary. The new line was named after George MacCartney, the British consul in Xinjiang's main town Kashgar, and Sir Claude MacDonald, a British minister to the Qing rulers of China. MacDonald came to be better known as the man who negotiated and secured from China the 99-year lease of the New Territories